



AI-GENERATED SECTOR PHOTOGRAPH · FINTECH / PAYMENTS · DARK TREATED

BRIEF

US Digital Payments Benchmarking

July 2026 · Caspr Analysis

Caspr.

PAYMENTS SECTOR BRIEF — US DIGITAL PAYMENTS BENCHMARKING

\$10.86 trillion

Projected U.S. digital-payments market size, 2026 — up from \$10.0 trillion in 2025

No single player dominates all layers of U.S. digital payments. PayPal and Stripe lead online, Visa and Mastercard own in-store rails, and Apple Pay leads mobile wallets — multi-rail strategy is the only rational response to a structurally fragmented market.

Three structural realities define the U.S. digital payments market — and they point in different strategic directions

MARKET OVERVIEW & GROWTH

\$10.86_T

Projected U.S. digital payments, 2026

- Up from \$10.0T in 2025 — high-single-digit YoY growth
- Wallets and BNPL accelerating fastest among segments

▲ RISING

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

41.6% vs 22.7%

PayPal vs Stripe global online payment share, 2026

- No single player dominates all layers — PayPal leads online, Visa/MC in-store
- Fragmented leadership across online, POS, and P2P layers

◆ MIXED — FRAGMENTED

FINANCIAL & OPERATIONAL KPIS

\$4.61

Lost per \$1 of fraud — U.S. merchant fraud cost multiplier

- Visa 2025 revenue \$40.0B · PayPal 2025 revenue \$33.2B
- PayPal implied take rate 1.85% · Adyen net yield 17 bps

▲ FRAUD COSTS A TOP MARGIN DRAG

EMERGING TRENDS & STRATEGY

1,400₊

FedNow participating institutions by July 2025

- RTP processed 98M transactions worth \$80B in Q4 2024
- 72% of leaders expect AI-generated fraud as a major challenge by 2026

▲ INSTANT PAYMENTS, BNPL, STABLECOINS SCALING

- Average chargeback rate 0.17% in Q1 2025 — a persistent cost headwind for merchants

- Stablecoins moving into production settlement — Stripe, Visa, and Mastercard all active in 2025

- Block gross profit \$10.2B combines Cash App (\$6.3B) and Square (\$3.9B) ecosystems

01 Card rails still dominate spend, but wallets, BNPL, and instant payments are the growth layers

The U.S. digital-payments market reached \$10.0 trillion in 2025 and is projected to reach \$10.86 trillion by 2026, implying high-single-digit growth. Card rails remain the largest absolute volume, but the strategic growth benchmarks have shifted: digital wallets are the fastest consumer-adoption layer, BNPL continues to outgrow core card spend, and FedNow/RTP are the infrastructure modernisation benchmark. For 2025–2026 planning, treat cards as the scale baseline, wallets as the consumer growth indicator, and real-time payments as the infrastructure readiness signal.

SEGMENT	2025–2026 BENCHMARK VIEW	HEADLINE SIGNAL
Credit / debit cards	Largest share of U.S. noncash spend	Mature, lower-growth core
Digital wallets	High-single to low-double-digit growth	Fastest consumer adoption
BNPL	Double-digit growth from smaller base	Conversion-led expansion
Real-time payments	Triple-digit early-stage growth in pockets	Infrastructure catch-up

Source: Federal Reserve Payments Study, 2025; Caspr analysis.

02 No single player leads every layer — strategic implication is multi-rail, not winner-takes-all

PayPal holds approximately 41.6% of global online payment share versus Stripe at 22.7%, but online share does not translate to in-store or P2P dominance. Visa and Mastercard control the in-store acceptance rails. Apple Pay leads proximity wallets. Zelle leads P2P by volume. Block leads SMB POS. No single player's positioning survives across all layers — the market requires partnership and multi-rail strategy rather than competitive consolidation around one provider.

03 Fraud containment and API performance are becoming primary differentiators — AI-driven risk is next

Operational performance benchmarks are tightening. MRC's 2025 report identifies payment acceptance and false declines as top merchant concerns. LexisNexis estimates U.S. merchants lose \$4.61 for every \$1 of fraud loss — the multiplier effect of chargebacks, processing costs, and lost goods. Sift reported average chargeback rates of 0.17% in Q1 2025. Over one-third of businesses already use AI for fraud detection, and 72% of business leaders expect AI-generated fraud and deepfakes to become major challenges by 2026. The operational benchmark has shifted from gateway reliability to fraud-cost containment and authorization-rate optimisation.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Growth is in wallets, BNPL, and instant rails — card-rail dominance remains but the strategic opportunity is in the faster-growth layers sitting on top of it**
- **No single provider leads all layers — multi-rail strategy is not a hedge, it is the only rational response to a structurally fragmented market**
- **Fraud containment has become a board-level performance metric; the \$4.61 multiplier means fraud cost management is a margin decision, not an operational one**

A Study on U.S. digital payments would cover provider selection frameworks, multi-rail architecture decisions, and competitive financial benchmarking across PayPal, Stripe, Visa, Mastercard, Block, and Adyen — run it from your dashboard.